



State of Ohio Administrative Policy

Website Standardization

No: IT-08

Information Technology

Effective:

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Issued By:

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I. Purpose

The purpose of this policy is to establish website standardization, content management, and security requirements for Agency websites. The intent of these requirements is to create a degree of consistency and predictability among **Public-facing Web Pages**, while still providing the flexibility to design secure web pages that fit the unique needs of Agencies. The first occurrence of a defined term in the policy body outside of a title or heading is in bold, italic type, and is hyperlinked to the definition in Section IV.

II. Scope

This policy applies to all state agencies, boards, and commissions under the authority of the Governor (collectively referred to as Agency or Agencies). The majority of the requirements outlined within this policy apply only to Public-facing Web Pages. However, the following sections apply to Public-facing Web Pages as well as Agency web-facing applications: Section III.K. Browser Compatibility, Section III.L. **Transport Layer Security (TLS)** Certificates, Section III.P. **Identification** and **Authentication**, and Section III.Q. Website and Web-Facing Application Security.

In accordance with Ohio Revised Code (ORC) Section 125.183, the requirements related to **Covered Applications** outlined in Section III.C. of this policy apply to state agencies, which are defined as every organized body, office, or agency established by the laws of this state for the exercise of any

function of state government, other than any state-supported institution of higher education, the courts, or any judicial agency. State agency also includes the general assembly, any legislative agency, and the capitol square review and advisory board (collectively referred to as Agency or Agencies in section III.C.).

III. Policy

Agencies shall align with the website design and content management standards defined by the **InnovateOhio Platform** team when developing and maintaining Public-facing Web Pages on **State-controlled Websites**.

- A. **User Experience Digital Toolkit**: Agencies shall utilize the InnovateOhio Platform User Experience Digital Toolkit to design their public facing web pages. The toolkit includes the following:
1. Style Guide (e.g., accessibility, color palette, typography, dependencies, etc.)
 2. User Interface Controls (e.g., ads grid, accordions, arrows and popovers, badges, breadcrumbs, buttons, card carousel, checkboxes, labels, left and main navigation, maps, etc.)
 3. Content Components (e.g., charts, icons, lists, tables, etc.)
 4. Page Examples (e.g., form, landing, login, password reset, etc.)
 5. Layout (e.g., cards, dividers, form, grid system, etc.)
 6. Page Errors (e.g., 404-page, 500 page, etc.)
- B. **Branding**: Each Agency shall have both Agency and Ohio.gov branding. This branding shall be consistent on all Agency pages.
1. Branding shall comply with the style in effect on the Ohio.gov home page.
 2. Agencies are permitted to use their own logos and branding. Agencies with subordinate Agencies shall use the subordinate Agency brand in addition to a link to the Agency home page.
 3. Agency branding shall be linked to the home page of the Agency's website. Subordinate Agency branding shall link to the subordinate Agency home page.
- C. **Social Media**: The use of **Social Media** shall align with the following requirements:

1. Agencies shall only use State-approved Social Media, which includes, Facebook, Flickr, GovDelivery, Instagram, LinkedIn, Pinterest, WordPress, YouTube, and X.
2. The download and/or use of any unauthorized social media, including Covered Applications as defined in ORC Section 125.183, is prohibited.
 - a) All Covered Applications must be immediately removed from all **State-Owned** or leased devices.
 - b) Exceptions to the Covered Applications prohibition shall only be considered for **Law Enforcement Purposes** or **Security Purposes** and must be authorized by the state agency director and the state chief information security officer or their designees. For any proposed uses, the agency must document the measures that will be taken to mitigate against the security and privacy risks associated with the use of a Covered Application. Examples of possible mitigation strategies include:
 - (i) Accessing the Covered Application from a secure device that does not connect to the state's network or wireless services.
 - (ii) Ensuring that the device that is used to access the Covered Application does not store or transmit **Confidential Data**.
 - c) Any requests for exception shall be submitted to the Ohio Department of Administrative Services (DAS) Office of Information Security and Privacy (OISP) via the Security Exception Request form. The form is located within the IT Enterprise Services Portal under the "Services & Products/Security Services" category.
3. Agencies shall take measures to prevent the downloading, installation, or use of a Covered Application.
4. Agencies shall monitor their use of Social Media and State-Owned or leased devices to ensure compliance with this policy.
5. Agencies' Social Media content coordinators shall be reminded, at least annually, of the requirements regarding prohibited and appropriate use as outlined within Ohio Administrative Policy IT-04, "Use of Internet, E-mail and Other IT Resources."
6. Third party tracking from Social Media links, for example, social network sharing buttons, widgets or plug-ins, shall not be permitted unless explicitly approved by the Agency. If Social Media links are authorized by the Agency to track user activities, then this shall be disclosed in the website privacy statement.
7. Links to Social Media shall appear in the Social Media column of the State Directory, <https://ohio.gov/wps/portal/gov/site/help-center/state-directory/>.

- D. **Search Feature:** Each Agency shall have a search feature available and when technically feasible, utilize the InnovateOhio Platform search engine.
1. The search feature shall have the capability to perform searches within the Agency website.
 2. The search bar appearance and functionality shall be consistent across all Agency web pages.
- E. **Navigation:** Each Agency shall provide consistent navigation on each web page.
1. The primary navigation bar shall be implemented on all Agency web pages.
 2. The primary navigation bar shall be populated with Agency-specific links and shall remain consistent across all web pages of a division or department.
 3. Primary and secondary navigation shall be text-based; images or other formats shall not be used.
 4. All images with hyperlink capability shall include an alternative text (alt text) description that conveys the action that will be initiated when the user clicks on the link (e.g., destination).
 5. Navigation within self-contained or embedded content, such as interactive animations, video, or data visualizations, is permitted but should only be used within the context of the component.
- F. **Content Area Design:** The layout and organization of each web page content area shall remain primarily at the discretion of the Agency, department, or division; Agencies shall refer to the InnovateOhio Platform User Experience Digital Toolkit web page for content and user experience best practices.
- G. **Website Content:** Agencies shall comply with the following website content requirements. Each Agency shall maintain an accurate contact page containing the following information:
1. A general phone number that is answered by a person during business hours.
 2. A media relations phone number (if available).
 3. A general phone number that is answered by a person during business hours.
 4. An e-mail address or submission form for general concerns.

5. A physical mailing address.
 6. Contact pages shall be labeled "Contact."
- H. **Privacy Notice:** Agency websites shall provide a hyperlink to a privacy notice on every web page. At a minimum, the privacy notice shall include the following elements:
1. The privacy notice shall describe the types of personal information the Agency collects through the website and why it is necessary.
 2. The privacy notice shall provide an explanation of how the user's personal information is collected, including directly, such as through web applications and online forms, and indirectly, such as through website usage analytical tools.
 3. The privacy notice shall disclose how the Agency uses personal information collected through the website, including secondary uses and public record requirements.
 4. Agencies shall inform website users that they may have rights under ORC sections 149.43, 1347.08, 1347.09, and 1347.15 with respect to inspecting, obtaining, correcting, and disputing personal information the Agency collects or maintains through the website.
 5. ORC Section 1347.15 requires each Agency to post on its' website the policies adopted in accordance with that law. The privacy notice shall have a section labeled "Confidential Personal Information." The section will include links to the Agency's administrative rules, policies and procedures issued in accordance with ORC 1347.15. If an Agency does not maintain any confidential personal information under ORC 1347.15, it shall include a statement to that fact instead.
 6. Agencies shall provide website users with an Agency point of contact who addresses privacy questions. The contact information shall include the mailing address and at least one of the following: a telephone number, e-mail address or contact form.
 7. The privacy notice shall be kept up to date to accurately reflect Agency information practices. The privacy notice shall display the latest revision date.
 8. Privacy notices shall be consistent with all applicable laws that regulate the collection, use and maintenance of personal information.
 9. Each Agency's privacy notice link shall be labeled as "privacy" or "privacy notice." (Refer to the footer on Ohio.gov for an example of labeling.)
- I. **Content Management:** Agencies shall keep content up to date. Agencies shall develop a process for selecting and training content coordinators who are responsible for maintaining

Agency website content.

- J. **Mobile Ready:** Agencies shall utilize InnovateOhio Platform templates and components, available at ux.ohio.gov, to ensure a responsive user experience on any device (e.g., mobile phones, tablets).
- K. **Browser Compatibility:** Agency websites and web-facing applications shall render properly in the current, supported version of Chrome, Edge, Firefox, and Safari.
- L. **Transport Layer Security (TLS) Certificates:** All publicly accessible, State-controlled Websites and web-facing applications shall only provide information and services through a hypertext transfer protocol secure (https) connection, encrypted using TLS certificates.
 - 1. TLS certificates may be obtained, renewed, and revoked using the DAS Office of Information Technology (OIT) Digital Certificate Provisioning service.
 - 2. TLS certificates may also be obtained from an approved vendor.
 - 3. Website sessions shall be encrypted using current, supported TLS protocols.
- M. **Website Accessibility:** Agency websites shall comply with the accessibility requirements outlined in Ohio Administrative Policy IT-09, "Website Accessibility."
- N. **Domain Name Standardization:** Each Agency is required to have an Ohio.gov domain in accordance with the requirements outlined in Ohio Administrative Policy IT-06, "Ohio.gov Standardization & Registration of **Domain Names**."
- O. **Website Standardization Requirement Guidance:** For additional website standardization requirement guidance, Agencies shall refer to the InnovateOhio Platform User Experience Digital Toolkit web page, ux.ohio.gov.
- P. **Identification and Authentication:** Where Identification and Authentication are required for website functionality, Agencies shall leverage InnovateOhio Platform solutions.
- Q. **Website and Web-Facing Application Security:** Agencies shall ensure that the following

security requirements are satisfied when maintaining a public-facing website or web-facing application:

1. Information collected from users shall be encrypted in transit and at rest.
2. Vulnerability scans shall be routinely conducted by the DAS Office of Information Security and Privacy (OISP) and the results communicated to system and business owners. Critical or high severity vulnerabilities shall be promptly remediated or mitigated.
3. All public-facing websites or web-facing applications shall generate and store audit records. All audit records shall be stored for at least 30 days, longer if mandated by state or federal regulation, and on a system separate from the web host system.
4. Where applicable, Agencies shall ensure that public-facing websites and web-facing applications comply with the security and privacy requirements provided by regulating entities (e.g., Criminal Justice Information Services (CJIS), IRS Publication 1075, Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act (FERPA), Health Insurance Portability and Accountability Act (HIPAA), etc.).
5. Where collecting payment information, ensure compliance with regulatory requirements (e.g., Payment Card Industry (PCI), National Automated Clearing House Association (NACHA), etc.).

R. **InnovateOhio Platform Responsibilities:** The InnovateOhio Platform team shall:

1. Oversee the State of Ohio's digital presence and partner with Agencies to ensure their websites align with statewide requirements;
2. Maintain digital toolkit standards and resources;
3. Support and provide Agencies with access to a website content management tool;
4. Communicate any substantive changes in website standards or content management to Agencies and content coordinators in a timely manner; and
5. Work with the DAS OISP to institute denial of service protections.

IV. Definitions

A. Authentication. Verifying the identity of a user, process, or device, often as a prerequisite to

allowing access to resources in an information system.¹

- B. Confidential Data. This classification includes Data that is required to be protected by law or regulation, is intended for confidential use, and may not be copied or removed from an agency's operational control without authorized permission. This classification includes Data that, if compromised, may result in loss of life, serious injury, or other harm to an individual or group, or disruption to critical agency operations.
- C. Covered Applications. As defined in ORC Section 125 183, a "Covered Application" means all of the following:
 - 1. The TikTok application and service or any successor application or service developed or provided by ByteDance limited or an entity owned by ByteDance limited;
 - 2. The WeChat application and service or any successor application or service developed or provided by Tencent holdings limited or an entity owned by Tencent holdings limited;
 - 3. Any application or service owned by an entity located in China, including QQ International (QQi), Qzone, Weibo, Xiaohongshu (Little Red Book), Zhihu, Meituan, Toutiao, Alipay, Xiami Music, Tiantian Music, DingTalk/DingDing, Douban, Renren, Youku/Tudou, and Zhihu.
- D. Domain Names. A domain name is used to locate computers on the Internet and to allow users to reach websites. Each domain name has at least two components, the top-level domain (TLD) name and the secondary level domain (SLD) name. In terms of Ohio.gov, ".gov" is the TLD and "Ohio" is the SLD. A third level domain may be added to further distinguish a SLD. For the purposes of this policy, Agencies are required to have an Ohio.gov alias at the third level. Structurally, the domain name would conform to the following format: [Agency Name/Acronym].Ohio.gov. Refer to section O., Domain Name Standardization, of this policy for specific domain name requirements.
- E. Identification. An act or process that presents an identifier to a system so that the system can recognize a system entity (e.g., user, process, or device) and distinguish that entity from all others.²
- F. InnovateOhio Platform: The InnovateOhio Platform (IOP) was established as a result of Governor Mike DeWine's issuance of Executive Order 2019-15D Modernizing Information

¹ "NIST Special Publication 800-53 Revision 5, Security and Privacy Controls for Federal Information Systems and Organizations," U.S. Department of Commerce National Institute of Standards and Technology, September 2020 <<https://nvlpubs.nist.gov/nistpubs/SpecialPublications/NIST.SP.800-53r5.pdf>>.

² "CNSS Instruction No. 4009, National Information Assurance (IA) Glossary," Committee on National Security Systems, April 2010 <<https://www.hsdn.org/?abstract&did=7447>>.

Technology Systems in Agencies. The IOP provides integrated and scalable capabilities that enable Agencies to become more customer-centric and data-driven, delivering on Innovate Ohio's vision to better serve Ohioans. The platform creates an integrated customer experience that brings higher-quality services to the public.

- G. Security Purposes. As referenced in this policy, Covered Applications may be used for Security Purposes, which may include, but are not limited to, activities such as investigations to limit harm to individual, public, private, or the State of Ohio's physical or digital infrastructure through the identification of vulnerabilities, security weaknesses, or actionable threats.³
- H. Law Enforcement Purposes. As referenced in this policy, Covered Applications may be used for Law Enforcement Purposes, which may include, but are not limited to, activities that are performed by or in coordination with an agency that is part of the federal or state law enforcement community, in response to a law enforcement emergency, or in the course of investigating potential violations of federal or state statutes or regulations.⁴
- I. Public-facing Web Pages. Public-facing Web Pages are web pages that are accessed via the World Wide Web by any Internet user throughout the world. Public-facing Web Pages include information available to the general public, but do not include intranets, extranets, e-mail, or applications.
- J. Social Media. Refers to an online environment or application that facilitates user participation, networking, and collaboration through the submission of user generated content. In general, this includes tools such as: blogs, wikis, microblogging sites, social networks, video sharing sites, and bookmarking sites.
- K. State-controlled Websites. Websites developed and maintained by Ohio Agencies, or under contracts administered by Ohio Agencies.
- L. State-Owned. Purchased with state funds or otherwise acquired by the state; property of the State of Ohio.
- M. Transport Layer Security (TLS). An Authentication and encryption protocol widely implemented in browsers and Web servers. HTTP traffic transmitted using TLS is known as HTTPS.⁵

³ Young, Shalanda, M-23-13 Memorandum for the Heads of Executive Departments and Agencies, Executive Office of the President, Office of Management and Budget, 27 February 2023.

⁴ *Ibid.*

⁵ Regenscheid, Andrew, Geoff Beier. NIST InterAgency or Internal Report 7711, "NIST Security Best Practices for the Electronic Transmission of Election Materials for UOCAVA Voters," U.S. Information Technology Laboratory National Institute of Standards and Technology, September 2011 <<https://nvlpubs.nist.gov/nistpubs/Legacy/IR/nistir7711.pdf>>.

V. Authority

ORC 125.18, 125.183

VI. Resources

Document Name	Location
Executive Order 2023-03D Prohibition of Certain Applications, Platforms, and Websites on State-Owned and State-Leased Devices	https://governor.ohio.gov/wps/portal/gov/governor/media/executive-orders
Executive Order 2019-14D Creating the InnovateOhio Advisory Board	https://governor.ohio.gov/wps/portal/gov/governor/media/executive-orders/2019-14d
Executive Order 2019-15D Modernizing Information Technology Systems in Agencies	https://governor.ohio.gov/wps/portal/gov/governor/media/executive-orders/2019-15d
Additional Website standardization requirement guidance	https://innovateohio.gov/ and https://ux.ohio.gov

VII. Inquiries

Direct inquiries regarding website design requirements to:

InnovateOhio Platform Team
Office of Information Technology
Ohio Department of Administrative Services
30 E Broad Street, 39th Floor
Columbus, Ohio 43215

Platform@InnovateOhio.gov

InnovateOhio Platform Team resources may be found online at
<https://iop.ohio.gov> and <https://ux.ohio.gov>.

Direct inquiries about this policy to:

State IT Policy Manager
Office of Information Technology
Ohio Department of Administrative Services
30 East Broad Street, 39th Floor
Columbus, Ohio 43215

1-614-644-6860 | DAS.State.ITPolicy.Manager@das.ohio.gov

State of Ohio Administrative Policies may be found online at
<https://das.ohio.gov/technology-and-strategy/policies>

To obtain the Digital Certificate Provisioning Service, contact the:

Customer Service Center
Office of Information Technology
Ohio Department of Administrative Services
1320 Arthur E. Adams Drive, Room 310
Columbus, Ohio 43221-3595

614-644-6860 | 877-644-6860 | csc@ohio.gov

VIII. Revision History

This policy shall be reviewed no less than every two years and updated as needed.

Date	Description of Change
03/03/2008	Original policy.
1/06/2012	Policy revised to reflect changes in Ohio's website design requirements.
12/21/2012	Revised the policy to remove all Ohio.gov domain related requirements and replaced them with a reference to Ohio Administrative Policy IT-06, "Ohio.gov Standardization & Registration of Internet Domain Names." This

Date	Description of Change
	update transfers all Ohio.gov related requirements to one statewide policy. Also, transferred the policy content into a new State of Ohio Administrative Policy Template. Re-numbered policy to IT-08 to be consistent with new numbering format.
01/15/2020	Updated the policy to incorporate the InnovateOhio Platform tools, standards, and format. The policy was also modified to reflect the change in administration.
03/06/2020	Updated the navigation requirements to reflect the current InnovateOhio Platform practice.
01/28/2021	Expanded the scope of the policy to all DAS OIT superintended Agencies. Added TLS certificate requirements, website security requirements, and modified privacy notice and content management requirements. Updated the browser compatibility section. Updated the policy to align with current terminology and processes.
10/14/2021	Conducted routine maintenance review of citations and references.
01/09/2023	Revised the Social Media requirements in section 2.3 to align with current, approved practices. Included a reference to Executive Order 2023-03D Prohibition of Certain Applications, Platforms, and Websites on State-Owned and State-Leased Devices. Added revision history review frequency statement and updated policy branding.
10/03/2023	Updated the Scope section in accordance with Ohio Revised Code Section 125.183. Aligned the policy with the requirements of Ohio Revised Code Section 125.183. Added and modified policy definitions. Updated the policy template.
04/29/2025	Replaced the term sensitive data, or sensitive information, with confidential data.